

Of Beaches and Cream

GianChand
Single Malt Whisky

The Indian single malt story is turning out to be a thriller. The intense heat and humidity of the subcontinent accelerate ageing, creating complex spirits in a fraction of the time needed for the process in Scotland.

The Indian whiskies, redolent with distinct expressions of flavours created as a result of the unique climatic conditions, are challenging the traditional dominance of Scotch whiskies. Amrut blazed the trail in 2004, while Paul John and Rampur followed with acclaimed releases that showcase India's diverse terroir. In 2022, GianChand, the single malt from Devans Modern Breweries in Jammu, emerged in the plot as a "gem from the lap of the Himalayas", as described by sommelier Shatbhi Basu. Named after Diwan Gian Chand, the founder of the brewery, the single malt with a rich amber gold liquor has a smooth character with a delicate fruity nose of sun-ripened apricots and a spice wrapped in a toffee sweetness. The aroma unfolds to reveal a mild peaty woody smokiness coming from the oak casks used for ageing the malt. Upon sipping, the whisky lands on the palette with a creamy honeyed sweetness and hints of salt and dried ginger that leave a trail of tannic astringency with a memory of spice. Last year, GianChand Single Malt (priced at ₹4,490 in Delhi) finished with a Silver at the International Wine & Spirit Competition. The jury described it as "an evocative whisky brimming with the sensual pleasures of a beach bonfire". Here's to arriving at the beach, on the rocks (even in Jammu)!